

18-Week Sprint Triathlon Training Plan

Intermediate Progression

Race Distance: 750m Swim | 20km Bike | 5km Run

Target Audience: Athletes with some triathlon experience or returning from break

Weekly Training: 5-6 days per week | 5-7 hours total

Program Structure: 4.5 cycles with extended build and intensity phases

Program Overview

This 18-week intermediate program extends the 12-week plan with longer build phases and more advanced interval work. It's designed for athletes who want more time to develop fitness or are returning to racing after a break.

Key Principles:

- Extended base building period
 - Progressive intensity increases
 - More advanced interval training
 - Multiple brick workouts per week
 - Open water swim preparation
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CYCLE 1: BASE BUILDING (Weeks 1-5)

Week 1: Test Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim Test (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5-10 min easy swim
- Main Set: Swim 15 min max distance
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim
- *Record distance for baseline*

Wednesday: Easy Bike (45 min)

Thursday: Run Test (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: Run/walk 30 min max distance
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Bike Test (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy
- Main Set: Bike 30 min max distance
- Cool-down: 5 min easy

Sunday: Easy Run (30 min)

Weekly Volume: ~4 hours

Week 2-3: Build Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim Build (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 6 x 3 min easy with 1 min recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (50 min)

Thursday: Run Build (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 4 x 5 min easy with 2 min recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Long Bike (75 min)

- Entire session easy/conversational pace
- Practice nutrition at 45 min mark

Sunday: Easy Run (35 min)

Weekly Volume: ~4.5 hours

Week 4: Build Week with Brick

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim Build (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 8 x 3 min easy with 1 min recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (50 min)

Thursday: Run Build (50 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 4 x 6 min easy with 2 min recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Bike + Run Brick (70 min)

- Bike: 12 min warm-up, 4 x 10 min at test pace (2 min easy between), 10 min cool-down

- Transition: 2-3 min
- Run: 8 min easy into race pace

Sunday: Easy Run (35 min)

Weekly Volume: ~5 hours

Week 5: Recovery Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Bike (45 min)

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Run (30 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2 hours

CYCLE 2: INTENSITY DEVELOPMENT (Weeks 6-10)

Week 6: Test Week (Retest)

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim Test (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5-10 min easy swim
- Main Set: Swim 15 min max distance
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (50 min)

Thursday: Run Test (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: Run/walk 30 min max distance
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Bike Test (50 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy
- Main Set: Bike 30 min max distance
- Cool-down: 10 min easy

Sunday: Easy Run (35 min)

Weekly Volume: ~4.5 hours

Week 7-8: Intensity Build

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim Intervals (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 6 x 4 min at test pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (50 min)

Thursday: Run Intervals (50 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 5 x 5 min at test pace with 2 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Long Bike (90 min)

- Warm-up: 12 min easy
- Main Set: 70 min easy/conversational
- Cool-down: 8 min easy

Sunday: Easy Run (40 min)

Weekly Volume: ~5.5 hours

Week 9: Build Week with Brick

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim Intervals (40 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 8 x 4 min at test pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (50 min)

Thursday: Run Intervals (55 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 6 x 5 min at test pace with 1.5 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Bike + Run Brick (80 min)

- Bike: 12 min warm-up, 5 x 10 min at test pace (2 min easy between), 10 min cool-down
- Transition: 2-3 min
- Run: 10 min easy into race pace

Sunday: Easy Run (40 min)

Weekly Volume: ~6 hours

Week 10: Recovery Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Bike (45 min)

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Run (30 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2 hours

CYCLE 3: RACE PREPARATION (Weeks 11-15)

Week 11: Test Week (Final Assessment)

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim Test (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5-10 min easy swim
- Main Set: Swim 15 min max distance
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (50 min)

Thursday: Run Test (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: Run/walk 30 min max distance
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Bike Test (50 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy
- Main Set: Bike 30 min max distance
- Cool-down: 10 min easy

Sunday: Easy Run (35 min)

Weekly Volume: ~4.5 hours

Week 12-13: Race Simulation

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim Intervals (40 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 8 x 4 min at test pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (50 min)

Thursday: Run Intervals (55 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 6 x 5 min at test pace with 1.5 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Full Triathlon Simulation (90 min)

- Swim: 15 min easy (simulating 750m)
- Transition: 3-5 min
- Bike: 30 min easy (simulating 20km)
- Transition: 2-3 min
- Run: 10 min easy (simulating 5km)
- *Practice transitions, nutrition, pacing*

Sunday: Easy Run (40 min)

Weekly Volume: ~5.5 hours

Week 14: Peak Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim Intervals (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 10 x 4 min at test pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (50 min)

Thursday: Run Intervals (60 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 8 x 5 min at test pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Bike + Run Brick (85 min)

- Bike: 12 min warm-up, 5 x 11 min at test pace (2 min easy between), 10 min cool-down
- Transition: 2-3 min
- Run: 12 min easy into race pace
- *Final hard effort before taper*

Sunday: Easy Run (40 min)

Weekly Volume: ~6 hours

Week 15: Recovery Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Bike (45 min)

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Run (30 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2 hours

CYCLE 4: FINAL TAPER (Weeks 16-18)

Week 16: Begin Taper

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim Intervals (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 6 x 3 min at test pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (45 min)

Thursday: Run Intervals (50 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 4 x 4 min at test pace with 2 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

Friday: Easy Swim (15 min)

Saturday: Easy Bike (40 min)

Sunday: Easy Run (30 min)

Weekly Volume: ~4 hours

Week 17: Taper Continues

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Bike (40 min)

Friday: Easy Swim (15 min)

Saturday: Rest day

Sunday: Easy Run (25 min)

Weekly Volume: ~2.5 hours

Week 18: RACE WEEK

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Swim (15 min)

- Very easy, confidence-building

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Bike (25 min)

- Very easy, just moving

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Rest day - Final preparations

- Lay out all gear

- Review race plan
- Early bed time

Sunday: RACE DAY!

- Arrive 1-2 hours early
- Warm up gently
- Trust your 18 weeks of training
- Have fun!

Weekly Volume: ~0.5 hours

Training Terminology

Test Pace (TP): The pace you established during your test weeks.

Easy/Conversational Pace: You should be able to hold a conversation.

Warm-up (WU): Gradually increase heart rate and blood flow.

Main Set (MS): The primary focus of the workout.

Cool-down (CD): Gradually decrease intensity to aid recovery.

Recovery Interval (RI): Easy effort between hard efforts.

Nutrition During Training

Pre-Workout (30-60 min before):

- Banana with almond butter
- Toast with jam
- Rice cakes with honey

During Workout (sessions >90 min):

- Water with electrolytes

- Energy gels or sports drink

Post-Workout (within 30 min):

- Protein + carbs (chicken with rice, protein smoothie, turkey sandwich)
 - Rehydrate with electrolytes
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Recovery & Injury Prevention

Sleep: Aim for 7-9 hours per night.

Stretching: 10-15 min after each workout.

Foam Rolling: 5-10 min on rest days.

Listen to Your Body: If something hurts, take an extra rest day.

Race Week Checklist

- ☐ Lay out all gear the night before
 - ☐ Check weather forecast
 - ☐ Review race course map
 - ☐ Plan parking and arrival time
 - ☐ Practice race-day breakfast
 - ☐ Get good sleep 2-3 nights before
 - ☐ Reduce training volume by 70%
 - ☐ Maintain intensity but reduce duration
 - ☐ Eat familiar foods only
 - ☐ Hydrate consistently
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Remember: This is YOUR training plan. Adjust rest days as needed to fit your life. Consistency beats perfection. Trust the process!